

While bitcoin's price was declining, its developers plowed forward with improving the protocol and building applications atop it. During that time, conversations about the underlying technology gained momentum, as early Bitcoiners⁹ emphasized that Bitcoin was important not only because of the decentralized currency aspect but also because of the architecture that supported it. This emphasis on the technology supporting Bitcoin came about just as a slew of developers and enterprises began to investigate Bitcoin because of the headlines that had grabbed their attention. Clearly, something was going on, and newcomers to the technology were trying to figure out what.

The trifecta of current Bitcoiners defending and explaining the disruptive potential of Bitcoin's technology, bitcoin's price descending dramatically, and newcomers investigating the technology led to a seismic shift in the Bitcoin narrative. Newcomers didn't necessarily see the need for bitcoin in the ways in which they wanted to use blockchain technology, and they felt reaffirmed in their belief by the continued descent of bitcoin's price through 2014. But to Bitcoiners it had always been "bitcoin *and* blockchain." The asset, bitcoin, was what incentivized an ecosystem of players—miners, developers, companies, and users—to secure and build upon Bitcoin's blockchain, delivering means of exchange and store of value services to the world.

Out of this examination of the technology underlying Bitcoin, two movements exploded in the blockchain technology space. One was the proliferation of new